BIMS-LEGAL: Dual-Store Soft Binding for Recovering Prior Legal Advice under Same-Domain Interference

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Abstract

Recovering prior client-specific advice from a legal consultation archive is difficult because dense retrieval may rank a relevant question turn highly while omitting the lawyer's answer—an *episode incompleteness* failure under same-domain interference. BIMS-LEGAL is a dual-store system for Chinese legal consultation logs: a fast episodic turn index with session identifiers and a slower BIRCH semantic store. Soft O2 performs turn-level session binding by giving siblings attenuated inherited scores (βs) rather than hard score copy. We evaluate exact replay as diagnostic and use paraphrase, follow-up, and advice-recall as primary non-exact channels. Primary Soft O2 contrasts use a shared turn-level index against dense FlatIP, hard hydration, and shuffled-*sid* controls; Soft O2 is strongest on non-exact channels where a partial episode hit can bind its answer sibling. Soft O2-C and gated Hybrid are reported as exploratory, gold-assisted solvability bounds for cross-session recovery—complementary to Soft O2, not replacements for it, and not claims about natural unsupervised BIRCH deployment. We report corrected graded nDCG alongside Answer Hit and Episode Completeness, with paired significance tests and a failure taxonomy separating complete, incomplete, and missed-session retrieval.

Keywords: legal information retrieval, consultation memory, soft episode

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binding, dual-store memory, cluster binding, Chinese legal corpora

1. Introduction

A junior associate may ask a firm assistant: "Last month you advised this client on terminating a fixed-term contract—what remedy did we recommend?" The system returns several near-identical "contract termination" questions, ranks the stored user utterance highly, and never surfaces the partner's written advice. The subsequent reply may sound fluent yet be grounded in the wrong episode—or in none. In consultation archives, questions and answers share specialized terminology; neighbouring matters are topically adjacent yet legally distinct; and the professionally useful evidence unit is the full consultation *episode*.

Legal informatics has long studied statutory interpretation, case retrieval, and advisory systems Martinez-Gil (2023); Ashley (2017). Recent legal large language models (LLMs) improve statutory and fact-pattern answering Yue et al. (2023); Huang et al. (2023); Yue et al. (2024). Classical legal information retrieval (IR) mainly targets *external* authority—statutes, cases, or community answers—as documents Askari et al. (2024); Louis et al. (2024); Liu et al. (2022); Zhang et al. (2024). Memory-augmented dialogue systems recover evidence from evolving conversation logs Wu et al. (2024); Maharana et al. (2024); Packer et al. (2023). The gap addressed here is *internal consultation memory*: retrieving prior client-specific advice from a growing same-domain archive under lexical interference.

BIMS-LEGAL is a dual-store Brain-Inspired Memory System for legal consultation archives, designed and evaluated in this study. The *systemic contribution* is a dual-store architecture that separates a fast episodic pathway (timestamped turn embeddings with speaker role and session identifier *sid*) from a slow semantic pathway based on Balanced Iterative Reducing and Clustering using Hierarchies (BIRCH) with deferred consolidation Zhang et al. (1996). Complementary Learning Systems (CLS) theory McClelland et al. (1995); Kumaran et al. (2016) supplies an architectural analogy for this dual-pathway design, not an empirical claim about biological memory. Under same-domain interference, dense turn retrieval in a vector database often returns a question turn while its answer sibling remains outside top-k—a system-level episodic memory failure we term *episode incompleteness*, distinct from a full session miss and exacerbated by IVFPQ score collapse and context fragmentation at moderate archive sizes.

The *algorithmic contributions* are soft binding operators that complete episodes without hard score copy:

- **Soft O2 (session soft binding).** When a turn is retrieved with score s, siblings sharing sid inherit $\max(s_{t'}, \beta \cdot s)$, surfacing answer turns under question-hit / answer-miss while preserving rank competition among candidates.
- **Soft O2-C and gated Hybrid (cluster soft binding).** The same soft-inheritance rule applies within BIRCH clusters when gold evidence is not co-session with the query; Hybrid triggers cluster binding only on direct dense hits to avoid displacing same-session siblings.

Two **implementation and scale design operators** support rigorous large-scale shared-store experiments but are not standalone algorithmic contributions:

- **O1 (exact FlatIP indexing).** At hundreds-to-thousands of turns, IVFPQ product quantization is under-trained and collapses Answer Hit; FlatIP restores faithful turn scores so Soft O2 inherits uncorrupted sibling signals.
- **O3 (bulk-load consolidation).** Deferred BIRCH and disk writes make archive construction tractable without changing retrieval semantics.

We ask four research questions:

- **RQ1.** Under same-domain interference, does episode incompleteness (question hit / answer miss) dominate full session miss?
- **RQ2.** Do Soft O2 and Soft O2-C address episode incompleteness under measured index distortion, and what incremental gains does Soft O2 provide over FlatIP and hard parent hydration?
- **RQ3.** On the *same* LegalEp /LegalMem stores, when is the slow (BIRCH) pathway effective? Does Soft O2-C help under standard same-session gold, and under a fair Mix of same-/cross-session gold?
- **RQ4.** Across CAIL multi-turn and LegalEp paraphrase /advice-recall channels, how large and session-tied are Soft O2 gains, and how do Soft O2 and Soft O2-C /Hybrid complement each other?

Contributions..

1. A dual-store memory architecture for Chinese legal consultation archives, separating fast episodic turn recovery from slower BIRCH semantic integration under same-domain interference.
2. Soft O2, a turn-level session soft-binding operator that addresses episode incompleteness without hard parent hydration or session-max score copy—the primary algorithmic claim before Soft O2-C.
3. A conservative three-candidate diagnostic of Soft O2 score competition using the gap ratio $\rho = s_d/s_h$; default β=0.98 is chosen by validation sweep, not by a closed-form optimum.
4. Turn-level lexical and fusion controls (BM25-turn, dense+BM25 RRF, cross-encoder) under the same evidence unit as Soft O2; joint episode / document-level indexes are a different input granularity and are not claimed as Soft O2 competitors here.
5. Exploratory Soft O2-C / gated Hybrid results under a gold-assisted Mix solvability bound, plus corrected nDCG, failure taxonomy, and paired significance reporting.
6. O1 exact FlatIP and O3 bulk-load consolidation as implementation operators enabling the shared-store ablations reported here.

Section 2 reviews related work. Section 3 presents BIMS-LEGAL operators and the Soft O2 diagnostic model. Section 4 details corpora, corrected metrics, and protocols. Section 5 reports results. Section 6 discusses implications and limitations. Section 7 concludes.

2. Related Work

2.1. Legal IR and long-horizon dialogue memory

Legal QA and retrieval systems typically ground generation in statutes, cases, or published advice Louis et al. (2024); Askari et al. (2024); Martinez-Gil (2023); Ashley (2017). Conversational legal case retrieval and event-aware similar-case ranking further show how interaction context and structured legal knowledge shape IR effectiveness Liu et al. (2022); Zhang et al. (2024). Those pipelines optimize access to external authority. Consultation memory retrieval targets a different evidence source: *prior consultation episodes* inside an agent's own archive. Confusing two clients' histories can produce fluent yet professionally inappropriate responses even when statute retrieval is correct. Domain LLMs such as DISC-LawLLM, Lawyer LLaMA, and LawLLM improve statutory and advisory generation Yue et al. (2023); Huang et al. (2023); Yue et al. (2024), but they still need a reliable memory index when prior advice must be recovered from a growing same-domain log.

Legal consultation archives add a further difficulty: high lexical overlap among topically adjacent matters, with the professionally useful evidence unit being the full question–answer episode. This setting motivates *dual-store* memory architectures that keep fast episodic turn retrieval separate from slower semantic clustering, and session-aware soft binding operators that recover answer turns under same-domain interference without collapsing rank competition among unrelated candidates.

2.2. Dual-store memory and episodic retrieval

Dual-store designs distinguish fast episodic encoding from slower semantic integration McClelland et al. (1995); Kumaran et al. (2016); Tulving et al. (1972); Atkinson and Shiffrin (1971). Memory architectures for dialogue agents extend context via hierarchical paging, summary banks, graphs, and neuro-symbolic retrieval Packer et al. (2023); Zhong et al. (2024); Rasmussen et al. (2025); Gutiérrez et al. (2024); Modarressi et al. (2023); Wang et al. (2024); Lewis et al. (2020); Wu et al. (2025), but most treat retrieved units as flat passages rather than *multi-turn consultation episodes* whose answer turn may rank below an unrelated question turn sharing legal vocabulary. LongMemEval and LoCoMo evaluate long-horizon recall and QA over personal conversation logs Wu et al. (2024); Maharana et al. (2024), while broader memory-agent surveys emphasize persistence beyond the context window Wu et al. (2025); Tan et al. (2025). Recent conversational RAG work stresses reuse of historical search evidence across turns Mo et al. (2026). BIMS-LEGAL positions its dual-store contribution at this intersection: episodic turn embeddings with *sid* for same-session recovery (Soft O2), and BIRCH centroids with Soft O2-C for cross-session recovery when query and gold evidence occupy different sessions but share thematic structure Zhang et al. (1996). Soft O2 directly addresses the episodic retrieval challenge that parent-document hydration and session-max aggregation handle via hard score copy: under dense same-domain interference, a question turn can dominate top-k while its answer sibling remains absent, producing fluent yet ungrounded downstream generation unless siblings enter under attenuated inherited scores.

2.3. Session-aware retrieval

Parent-document hydration, session aggregation, and joint session indexing are standard session-aware mechanisms for attaching sibling context to a dense hit. Soft episode binding (Soft O2) inherits $\beta \cdot s$ for siblings and keeps ranking competition among candidates. Parent-document and hierarchical retrieval similarly attach child evidence to a parent unit Callan et al. (1994); Dai et al. (2019); Zaheer et al. (2017); Karpukhin et al. (2020); Soft O2 differs by using attenuated turn-level score propagation rather than hard hydration or atomic session documents. Lexical BM25 Robertson and Zaragoza (2009), dense passage retrieval Karpukhin et al. (2020), dense–sparse Reciprocal Rank Fusion Cormack et al. (2009), and cross-encoder reranking Nogueira et al. (2019); Chen et al. (2024) provide complementary controls outside session membership. Exact flat indexes and product-quantized ANN backends Johnson et al. (2019) further affect whether sibling binding is applied over faithful turn scores. Table 1 summarizes the session-structure contrasts used in the main grids.

Table 1: Session-aware mechanisms compared in this work.

Mechanism	**Unit**	**Expansion**	**Type**	**Rank**
Parent hydration	Session	Insert siblings	Hard	No
Session-max	Session	Session max	Hard	Same*
Joint episode index	Session doc	Atomic	N/A	N/A
Soft O2	Turn+sid	Soft βs	Soft	Yes
Soft O2-C	Turn+cluster	Soft $\beta_c s$	Soft	Yes

*On the reported corpora, session-max rankings coincide with hard parent hydration under full-sibling expansion; main tables report a single hard-expansion baseline. Soft O2 denotes session soft binding; Soft O2-C denotes cluster soft binding on the BIRCH pathway.

We reuse CLS vocabulary as an architectural analogy for BIMS-LEGAL: turn embeddings with timestamps, roles, and session identifiers as episodic elements; Soft O2 as episode binding on the episodic pathway; BIRCH centroids with Soft O2-C as semantic integration on the slow pathway; and shared-store distractors as interference. The dual-store split is the systemic design; Soft O2 and Soft O2-C are the algorithmic mechanisms evaluated on Chinese legal consultation archives.

3. Method: BIMS-LEGAL

3.1. Architecture overview

Figure 1 summarizes the pipeline. BIMS-LEGAL maintains complementary episodic and semantic stores over the same consultation archive.

Definition 1 (Episodic and semantic elements)**.** *An episodic element is* $e_i = (\mathbf{v}_i, t_i, c_i, \phi_i, sid_i)$*, where* $\mathbf{v}_i \in \mathbb{R}^d$ *is an embedding,* t_i *a timestamp,* c_i *conversational context (including speaker role),* ϕ_i *surface features, and* sid_i *the consultation session identifier. A semantic element is* $s_j = (\mathbf{c}_j, C_j, \kappa_j, \tau_j)$ *with centroid* $\mathbf{c}_j$*, member set* C_j*, label* κ_j*, and formation statistics* τ_j*. Write* $\mathrm{Sib}(t) = \{t' : sid_{t'} = sid_t\} \setminus \{t\}$ *for session siblings and* $\mathrm{Clus}(t) = \{t' : cid_{t'} = cid_t\} \setminus \{t\}$ *for BIRCH-cluster siblings.*

Definition 2 (Dual-store retrieval map)**.** *Given query* q *with embedding* $\mathbf{v}_q$*, base episodic retrieval returns a scored candidate set* $\mathcal{R}_0(q) = \{(t, s_t)\}$ *under Eq.* (1)*. Soft O2 produces* $\mathcal{R}_{\mathrm{O2}}(q) = \mathsf{SoftBind}(\mathcal{R}_0(q); \mathrm{Sib}, \beta)$ *(Section 3.3). Soft O2-C produces* $\mathcal{R}_{\mathrm{O2C}}(q) = \mathsf{SoftBind}(\mathcal{R}_0(q); \mathrm{Clus}, \beta_c)$ *(Section 3.5). Gated Hybrid composes session binding then cross-session cluster binding (Algorithm 2). The returned list is the top-*k *of the bound set under the rewritten scores.*

3.2. Base scoring and implementation operators (O1, O3)

For query q with embedding $\mathbf{v}_q$, episodic base retrieval scores a memory turn m by

$$\mathrm{score}(m) = \alpha\, S(\mathbf{v}_q, \mathbf{v}_m) + (1-\alpha)\, R(t_m), \tag{1}$$

where S is cosine similarity on ℓ_2-normalized embeddings and

$$R(t_m) = \max\left(0,\ 1 - \frac{\Delta_t}{30 \text{ days}}\right), \tag{2}$$

with Δ_t the elapsed time between query time and the turn timestamp. Unless stated otherwise, α=0.7. Eq. (1) is the ranking score used throughout the legal grids; Soft O2 /Soft O2-C rewrite sibling scores after this fusion step and do not replace Eq. (1).

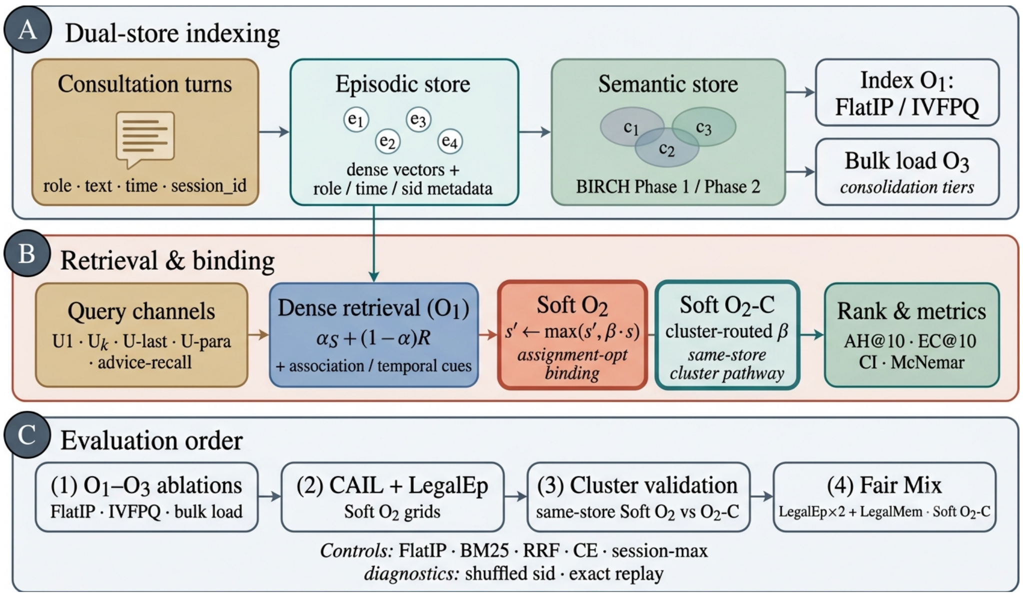

Figure 1: BIMS-LEGAL dual-store pipeline. (A) Episodic turn indexing and BIRCH semantic clustering (O3 bulk-load consolidation). (B) Query-time dense retrieval under O1 FlatIP with Soft O2 session binding and Soft O2-C cluster binding (algorithmic core); O1 and O3 are implementation operators. (C) Evaluation order: shared-store ablations, CAIL /LegalEp Soft O2 grids, same-store cluster validation, and fair Mix Soft O2-C.

O1: Exact FlatIP indexing.. Let $\widehat{S}$ denote the similarity induced by an ANN backend. At hundreds to a few thousand turns, FAISS IVFPQ is often under-trained, so $\|\widehat{S} - S\|$ is large enough to reorder turns and break Soft O2 inheritance. O1 forces $\widehat{S} = S$ via exact FlatIP (inner-product search on ℓ_2-normalized embeddings). Quantization error depresses Answer Hit (Table A.8: IVFPQ AH 0.330 at M=1600 on LegalEp-DISC exact). O1 is an engineering prerequisite for rigorous Soft O2 evaluation, not a standalone retrieval algorithm.

O3: Bulk-load consolidation.. During bulk construction, O3 replaces the per-insert update $(e_i \mapsto \mathsf{BIRCH}(e_i);\ \mathsf{Flush})$ by a deferred operator $\mathsf{Finalize} = \mathsf{BIRCH}(\{e_i\}_{i=1}^{N}) \circ \mathsf{Flush}$, executed once after all episodic writes. O3 does not change retrieval semantics; it makes $M{\geq}400$ shared-store experiments runnable ($\approx$ 11 min wall-clock for M=400; amortized $\approx$ 0.825 s/turn over $\sim$ 800 turns). Quality–latency curves to M=6400 appear in Section 5.6.

Algorithm 1 Soft O2 session soft binding

Require: Query q, base hits $\mathcal{R}_0$, top-k, attenuation β

$\mathcal{R} \leftarrow \mathcal{R}_0$
for each hit $t \in \mathcal{R}_0$ with score s_t **do**
    for each sibling $t' \in \mathrm{Sib}(t)$ absent from $\mathcal{R}$ **do**
        insert $(t', \beta \cdot s_t)$ into $\mathcal{R}$
    end for
end for
▷ Completeness pass after fusion with Eq. (1)
for each session sid represented in $\mathcal{R}$ **do**
    $s_{\max} \leftarrow \max\{s_u : u \in \mathcal{R},\ sid_u = sid\}$
    for each $t' \in$ Sib of sid still absent **do**
        insert $(t', \beta \cdot s_{\max})$ into $\mathcal{R}$
    end for
end for
return top-k of $\mathcal{R}$ by descending score

3.3. Soft O2: session soft binding

Motivation.. Under same-domain interference, a retrieved question turn can score highly while its answer sibling remains outside top-k—episode incompleteness compounded by IVFPQ score collapse and context fragmentation. Soft O2 completes episodes without hard score copy.

Definition 3 (Soft binding operator)**.** *Given a scored set $\mathcal{R} = \{(t, s_t)\}$, a sibling relation $\mathcal{N}(\cdot)$, and attenuation $\beta \in (0, 1]$, define*

$$\mathsf{SoftBind}(\mathcal{R}; \mathcal{N}, \beta): \quad s_{t'} \leftarrow \max\big(s_{t'},\ \beta \cdot s_t\big) \quad \textit{for all } t \in \mathcal{R},\ t' \in \mathcal{N}(t). \tag{3}$$

Soft O2 is $\mathsf{SoftBind}(\cdot; \mathrm{Sib}, \beta)$ with default β=0.98. Hard parent hydration is the special case β=1 with forced insertion of all siblings; session-max replaces each member score by $\max_{t \in sid} s_t$.

Algorithm 1 states the deployed Soft O2 procedure (expand + completeness truncate), matching the public implementation.

3.4. Soft O2 attenuation as diagnostic score competition

The attenuation β controls how strongly a retrieved turn promotes its session siblings. We treat the following as a *diagnostic* model, not a proof of a universal optimum. In particular, a zero-margin hinge objective with $\beta \in (0, 1]$ does not identify a meaningful quantile solution: when the rank margin is zero, the rank term is inactive for all $\beta < 1$, so its weight cannot determine a closed-form optimum.

Definition 4 (Three-candidate diagnostic model)**.** *For a query whose dense retrieval directly hits a gold turn h with fused score $s_h > 0$, let a be the gold answer sibling and let d be the strongest non-session distractor in a wide candidate pool, with scores s_a and s_d. Soft O2 rewrites*

$$s'_h = s_h, \qquad s'_a = \max(s_a, \beta s_h), \qquad s'_d = s_d, \tag{4}$$

and defines the gap ratio $\rho = s_d/s_h$. Because d is the strongest measured distractor, conditions based on ρ are conservative sufficient conditions for beating that distractor, not exact top-k boundary conditions for every competitor.

The binding analysis is most relevant in the soft-injection regime $s_a \le \beta s_h$, where $s'_a = \beta s_h$.

Proposition 1 (Feasible attenuation band)**.** *Under Definition 4, assume the soft-injection case $s_a \le \beta s_h$. Then (i) availability against the measured distractor requires $\beta > \rho$; (ii) rank preservation of the direct hit over the injected sibling requires $\beta < 1$, and more generally $s'_a < s_h$; (iii) when $\rho < 1$, any $\beta \in (\rho, 1)$ satisfies both conditions in the active injection case. If $s_a > s_h$ already, rank preservation depends on the observed sibling score rather than on β alone.*

Proof. If $s_a \le \beta s_h$, then $s'_a = \beta s_h$. Availability follows from $\beta s_h > s_d$, i.e. $\beta > \rho$. Rank preservation requires $s'_a < s_h$, which reduces to $\beta < 1$ when $s_h > 0$. □

Exploratory soft-rank diagnostic.. We also minimize an exploratory soft pairwise diagnostic on a validation grid,

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{sr}}(\beta; \rho) = -\log \sigma\big(\tau(\beta - \rho)\big) - \gamma \log \sigma\big(\tau(1 - \beta)\big), \tag{5}$$

with logistic σ, temperature τ, and rank weight γ. This visualization is useful for studying the availability–ranking trade-off, but it depends on the diagnostic pool, query channel, and chosen hyperparameters. Default β=0.98

Table 2: Diagnostic gap-ratio statistics on LegalEp M=3000 stores (exact-channel query proxy; strongest measured non-session distractor). These are calibration diagnostics, not derivations of an optimal β.

Corpus	ρ_{50}	ρ_{95}	Cover@0.90	Default β
LegalEp-DISC	0.746	0.854	0.981	0.98
LegalEp-Lawyer	0.662	0.815	0.998	0.98

is selected from the sweep in Table A.6, where $\{0.90, 0.95, 0.98\}$ form a stable high-AH band.

Fair controls include hard parent hydration, session-max aggregation, and shuffled *sid*. On two-turn LegalEp episodes, hard hydration and session-max coincide under full-sibling expansion; we report a single hard-expansion baseline. Indexes that concatenate an entire question–answer episode into one retrieval unit (BM25-joint or dense joint-episode documents) change the input granularity and are therefore outside the Soft O2 turn-level protocol; we do not report them as Soft O2 competitors.

3.5. Semantic consolidation and Soft O2-C

Semantic consolidation follows a BIRCH-style dual-phase procedure Zhang et al. (1996).

Definition 5 (BIRCH dual-phase consolidation)**.** *Let* $\{\mathbf{c}_j\}$ *be current centroids and* θ_H, θ_M *the assign /merge thresholds.* ***Phase 1 (assign).*** *For a new embedding* $\mathbf{v}$*, set* $j^\star = \arg\max_j S(\mathbf{v}, \mathbf{c}_j)$*; if* $S(\mathbf{v}, \mathbf{c}_{j^\star}) \geq \theta_H$ *then* $C_{j^\star} \leftarrow C_{j^\star} \cup \{\mathbf{v}\}$ *and refresh* $\mathbf{c}_{j^\star}$*, else spawn a new cluster.* ***Phase 2 (merge).*** *Periodically, merge pairs with* $S(\mathbf{c}_i, \mathbf{c}_j) \geq \theta_M$ *and purge near-duplicates above a redundancy threshold. Under O3, both phases run inside* $\mathsf{Finalize}$*. Each turn* t *receives a cluster id* cid_t*, inducing* $\mathrm{Clus}(t)$ *in Definition 1.*

Definition 6 (Soft O2-C)**.** *Soft O2-C is* $\mathsf{SoftBind}(\cdot; \mathrm{Clus}, \beta_c)$ *with default* β_c=0.95 $< \beta$*, reflecting noisier thematic neighbourhoods than session membership. A per-cluster sibling budget* B_c *caps* $|\mathrm{Clus}(t) \cap \mathrm{Injected}|$ *so large thematic clusters cannot flood top-*k*.*

Gated Hybrid (Algorithm 2) injects only *cross-session* cluster siblings relative to sessions already covered by dense /Soft O2 hits, and triggers cluster binding only on direct dense hits. This prevents thematic confusers

Algorithm 2 Gated Hybrid Soft O2 + Soft O2-C

Require: Base hits $\mathcal{R}_0$, budgets (k, B_c), attenuations (β, β_c)

$\mathcal{R} \leftarrow \mathsf{SoftBind}(\mathcal{R}_0; \mathrm{Sib}, \beta)$ ▷ session pathway first
$\mathcal{S}_{\mathrm{cov}} \leftarrow \{sid_t : t \in \text{top-}k(\mathcal{R})\}$
$\mathcal{T}_{\mathrm{trig}} \leftarrow \{t \in \mathcal{R}_0\}$ ▷ direct dense hits only
for each trigger $t \in \mathcal{T}_{\mathrm{trig}}$ **do**
    $s_{\max} \leftarrow \max\{s_u : u \in \mathcal{R},\ cid_u = cid_t\}$
    for each $t' \in \mathrm{Clus}(t)$ with $sid_{t'} \notin \mathcal{S}_{\mathrm{cov}}$, up to budget B_c **do**
        $s_{t'} \leftarrow \max(s_{t'}, \beta_c \cdot s_{\max})$
    end for
end for
return top-k of $\mathcal{R}$

from displacing same-session siblings already recovered by Soft O2. Soft O2 and Soft O2-C are complementary: Soft O2 is the default binder when query and gold share *sid*; Soft O2-C is required when gold evidence is held in a different session but the same cluster.

4. Corpora and Evaluation Protocol

Figure 2 sketches the shared-corpus design used throughout the legal evaluation. Gold needles and same-domain distractors occupy one store. Each query probes that shared archive under fixed interference conditions. Privately rebuilt haystacks are avoided so that system comparisons isolate the retrieval operator.

4.1. Datasets and query channels

Multi-turn authenticity is evaluated on CAIL2024 consultation dialogues. Gold needles are authentic preliminary and final dialogues, with conversation turns completed by label turns where applicable. Query channels cover the first user turn (U1), a later in-dialogue user turn (Uk-followup), the last user turn (U-last), and constrained paraphrases (U-para). Evidence defaults to assistant turns in the target session.

LegalEp-DISC and LegalEp-Lawyer rebuild public DISC-Law-SFT and Lawyer-LLaMA subsets into consultation-episode corpora. Each episode is a natural (question, answer) pair with session identifier *sid*. Reconstruction

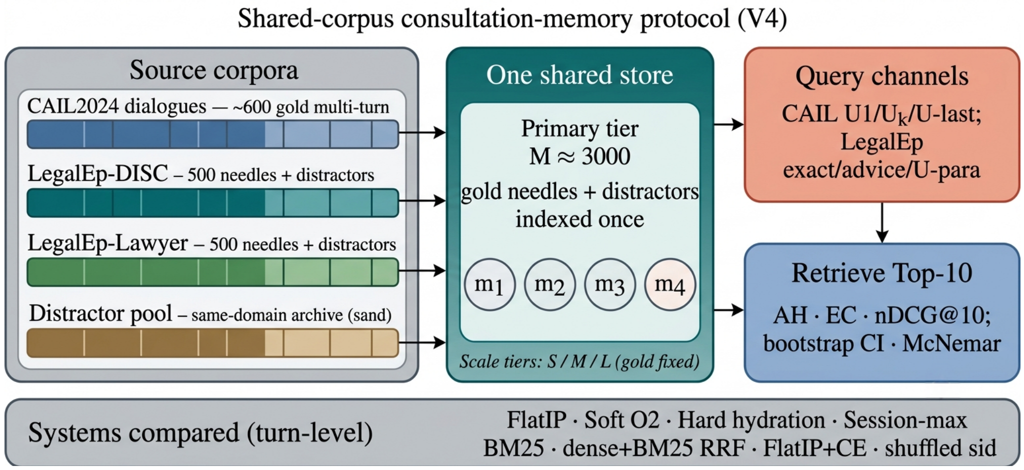

Figure 2: Shared-corpus protocol. Gold needles and same-domain distractors share one store; queries probe multiple channels with turn-level systems and significance tests. Exact replay is diagnostic; paraphrase, follow-up, and advice-recall are primary channels.

applies length bounds and legal-content filters, excludes exam prompts, removes near-duplicates, separates needles from distractors under a fixed seed, and retains an audit subsample. After filtering, each LegalEp corpus retains 3500 passed sessions (500 needles, 2500 distractors at the M=3000 primary tier).

Query-channel policy (addressing exact-match shortcuts).. Exact replay uses the stored user question and is reported only as a *diagnostic* upper bound on surface-form recovery. Primary claims use paraphrase, Uk-followup /U-last, and advice-recall queries whose surface form is not identical to the stored question text; paraphrase and advice-recall templates are generated under a fixed seed and audited on a subsample. LegalMem-MT reuses CAIL multi-turn gold under the same store for same-session Soft O2 vs Soft O2-C contrasts and for Mix reconstructions.

Archive size is varied with gold needles held fixed. Unless stated otherwise, Soft O2 transfer tables use the $M \approx 3000$ tier; O1–O2 ablations use M=400, S=300.

4.2. Metrics and baselines

Primary metrics are Answer Hit@k (AH), Episode Completeness@k (EC), and corrected normalized Discounted Cumulative Gain@k (nDCG) at k=10.

AH is binary: whether a gold answer turn appears in the top-k. EC is the mean coverage of gold turns within the target session. Session Hit@k is reported only for diagnosis. For nDCG we use fixed graded relevance over the full gold session: answer turns rel=1.0, other same-session turns rel=0.5, all other turns rel=0.0. The ideal denominator (IDCG) is computed from all gold-relevant turns in the target session and truncated at k, so every system on a query shares the same IDCG. Earlier draft values based on retrieved-item IDCG are not comparable. We therefore treat Answer Hit and Episode Completeness as the primary numeric claims in the main Soft O2 grids, report a failure taxonomy derived from Session Hit versus Answer Hit, and release a corrected-nDCG recompute script (`paper/scripts/recompute_corrected_metrics.py`) with fixed-gold IDCG artifacts under `paper/ipm/figures/`. Primary contrasts use bootstrap 95% CIs and McNemar mid-p tests on paired per-query hits; where families of related hypotheses are interpreted jointly, we also report Holm-corrected p-values (Table A.7).

Turn-level dense FlatIP (O1) is the base dense retriever. Soft O2 applies soft sibling score inheritance on the episodic pathway. Soft O2-C applies the analogous rule within BIRCH clusters. Hard parent hydration expands a hit to all siblings by copying the trigger score. Lexical controls include BM25 over turns and dense+BM25 Reciprocal Rank Fusion (RRF) under the same turn-level evidence unit. We do *not* include BM25-joint or dense joint-episode indexes in Soft O2 primary comparisons: those methods retrieve pre-concatenated episode documents and therefore answer a different retrieval problem. A cross-encoder (CE) control reranks the top-30 FlatIP candidates with `BAAI/bge-reranker-v2-m3`. Negative and sensitivity controls include shuffled *sid*, a β sweep, and IVFPQ as a quantization reference.

4.3. Fair Mix protocol for Soft O2-C

On fully same-session LegalMem grids, Soft O2 already recovers gold answers that share *sid* with the query, so Soft O2-C has little exclusive headroom and may inject thematic confusers. We therefore reconstruct the *same* LegalEp and LegalMem archives under a Mix protocol: 70% of gold episodes are split into query-side S_a and evidence-side S_b with distinct session identifiers, while 30% remain intact. Distractors are unchanged. All operators—FlatIP, Soft O2, Soft O2-C, and gated Hybrid—share unrestricted dense retrieval on this store; we report overall AH and stratum AH on `cross_session` vs `same_session` queries.

Glue as a solvability bound (not a retrieval cheat).. After BIRCH consolidation on the Mix store, each cross-session Sa/Sb split pair is *glued* into one cluster identifier. This step uses gold split metadata available only in the evaluation protocol—it does *not* inject labels at query time and is *not* used in real unsupervised clustering deployments. Its sole purpose is to establish a **solvability bound**: if Soft O2-C cannot recover cross-session gold when the semantic store *must* contain both halves of a split pair in one cluster, then failure reflects mechanism limits rather than accidental cluster separation. Glue therefore tests whether cluster soft binding *can* complete episodes when the slow pathway has the requisite thematic co-membership; natural same-cluster rates without glue are lower and are reported only as diagnostics (Section 6.3). Soft O2's session membership constraint is unchanged—glue affects only whether Soft O2-C has a cluster in which to bind, not whether Soft O2 receives privileged label access. LegalEp Mix uses advice-recall queries; LegalMem Mix uses mid-split Uk-followup queries. External LongMemEval /LoCoMo numbers from prior retrieval runs on this codebase (QA correctness 70.7% / 68.2% on released test splits) are cited only as long-horizon memory context Wu et al. (2024); Maharana et al. (2024), not as Soft O2-C evidence on legal corpora.

5. Experiments

Unless noted, the embedding model is `nomic-embed-text-v2-moe` Nussbaum et al. (2025), k=10, seed 42. We report primary contrasts in figures and keep full numeric grids in the appendix. Result files and scripts are released with the accompanying repository so that each table maps to a public JSON artifact.

5.1. Implementation operators and Soft O2 ablation

Table 3 reports the shared-store ablation on DISC-Law and Lawyer-LLaMA (M=400, S=300). IVFPQ baseline Answer Hit is 0.540 / 0.397. O1 alone yields a small gain on DISC (0.567) and a near-tie on Lawyer (0.397), confirming that exact indexing is a necessary implementation prerequisite but insufficient alone. O1+Soft O2 raises Answer Hit to 0.780 / 0.680 (+0.240 / +0.283 over baseline) and Episode Completeness to 0.888 / 0.840—the primary algorithmic gain. O3 is enabled for all configurations in this ladder as a construction prerequisite; it does not alter retrieval scores.

Table 3: O1+Soft O2 ablation on the shared store (M=400, S=300, k=10). EC denotes Episode Completeness (gold-turn coverage); AH denotes Answer Hit. O3 bulk-load is on for all rows. Boldface: best AH and EC within each corpus. Corrected nDCG is reported for the M≈3000 grids (Table 6), not for this small-store ladder.

Corpus	System	EC@10	AH@10
DISC-Law	IVFPQ baseline	0.770	0.540
	+ O1 FlatIP	0.782	0.567
	+ O1+O2 Soft O2	**0.888**	**0.780**
Lawyer-LLaMA	IVFPQ baseline	0.698	0.397
	+ O1 FlatIP	0.698	0.397
	+ O1+O2 Soft O2	**0.840**	**0.680**

5.2. RQ1 failure taxonomy

We classify each query into *complete* (answer evidence in top-k), *incomplete* (target session partially retrieved but answer missing), or *session miss* (no target-session turn in top-k). Table 4 contrasts FlatIP, Soft O2, hard hydration, and shuffled *sid* on primary non-exact channels. Soft O2 converts incompleteness into complete retrieval while session-miss stays nearly fixed; shuffled *sid* restores high incompleteness, so the gain is session-tied rather than generic score inflation. Hard hydration can also drive incompleteness near zero by copying trigger scores, but it is not Soft O2's binding rule and can over-promote siblings (Section 5.4).

5.3. Turn-level Soft O2 controls (primary V4 AH)

Primary Soft O2 claims use a shared turn-level index. Table 5 reports published V4 Answer Hit for FlatIP, Soft O2, hard hydration, and shuffled *sid* on the primary Soft O2 transfer channels. Soft O2 beats FlatIP on every non-exact channel; shuffled *sid* collapses toward or below FlatIP; hard hydration is competitive on CAIL AH but Soft O2 remains stronger on LegalEp paraphrase /advice and retains higher EC in the full grids (Tables A.1–A.3). BM25-turn is a same-granularity lexical control (Table A.4): Soft O2 exceeds it on CAIL Uk /U-last (0.698/0.762 vs 0.482/0.413). Joint episode / document-level indexes change evidence granularity and are not Soft O2 protocol competitors.

5.4. Soft O2 on session (CAIL and LegalEp)

Figure 3 and Table 5 summarize published V4 AH@10 on authentic CAIL multi-turn channels at $M \approx 3000$ under O1 FlatIP—these absolute AH levels

Table 4: RQ1 failure taxonomy (k=10, FlatIP rebuild). Boldface: best complete / lowest incomplete within each corpus–channel block among FlatIP, Soft O2, and shuffled *sid* (hard hydration shown as a score-copy envelope). Soft O2 cuts incompleteness without raising session miss; shuffled *sid* undoes the gain.

Corpus / channel	System	Complete	Incomplete	Session miss
DISC / u-para	FlatIP	70.8%	26.8%	1.6%
	Soft O2	**89.1%**	**8.7%**	1.8%
	Hard hydr.	97.2%	0.0%	2.8%
	Shuffled O2	66.4%	31.4%	2.2%
DISC / advice	FlatIP	48.0%	17.0%	35.0%
	Soft O2	**60.8%**	**3.8%**	35.4%
	Hard hydr.	65.0%	0.0%	35.0%
	Shuffled O2	45.6%	19.2%	35.2%
Lawyer / u-para	FlatIP	71.5%	25.3%	0.8%
	Soft O2	**94.0%**	**3.8%**	1.6%
	Hard hydr.	98.0%	0.0%	2.0%
	Shuffled O2	72.9%	25.5%	1.6%
CAIL / Uk	FlatIP	45.8%	54.0%	0.2%
	Soft O2	**92.8%**	**7.0%**	0.2%
	Hard hydr.	98.3%	1.5%	0.2%
	Shuffled O2	34.7%	65.2%	0.2%

are the Soft O2 transfer claims used throughout the paper. Soft O2 lifts Answer Hit over FlatIP on every channel (U1 0.788 vs 0.570**; Uk 0.698 vs 0.270**; U-last 0.762 vs 0.245**). Shuffled *sid* removes the gain (U1 0.452; Uk 0.230; U-last 0.200), tying the improvement to correct episode membership (RQ1–RQ2). In the same V4 AH/EC grids, hard expansion can raise AH slightly above Soft O2 (e.g., U1 0.802 vs 0.788) while lowering EC (U1 0.578 vs Soft O2 0.664). Soft O2 therefore behaves as a rank-preserving binder: siblings enter under attenuated scores, and episode coverage remains higher than under hard score copy. Under corrected fixed-gold IDCG on a fresh FlatIP rebuild (Table 6; absolute AH levels differ from V4), Soft O2 also raises nDCG over FlatIP—and over shuffled *sid*—on every listed non-exact channel while cutting incompleteness sharply (Table 4). Soft O2 still exceeds FlatIP+CE on every CAIL channel (Table A.5). Full V4 rows with corrected nDCG appear in Table A.1.

Figure 4 reports LegalEp transfer on the same published V4 AH grids.

Table 5: Primary Soft O2 controls (published V4 AH@10, $M \approx 3000$). Boldface: best AH within each row among FlatIP / Soft O2 / Hard / Shuffled. Soft O2 is the session-binding claim; shuffled *sid* is the membership negative control; hard hydration is score-copy expansion.

Corpus / channel	FlatIP	Soft O2	Hard	Shuffled
CAIL / U1	0.570	0.788	**0.802**	0.452
CAIL / Uk	0.270	0.698	**0.720**	0.230
CAIL / U-last	0.245	0.762	**0.790**	0.200
LegalEp-DISC / u-para	0.547	**0.648**	0.592	0.469
LegalEp-DISC / advice	0.342	**0.428**	0.402	0.310
LegalEp-Lawyer / u-para	0.568	**0.759**	0.596	0.592
LegalEp-Lawyer / advice	0.332	**0.472**	0.394	0.348

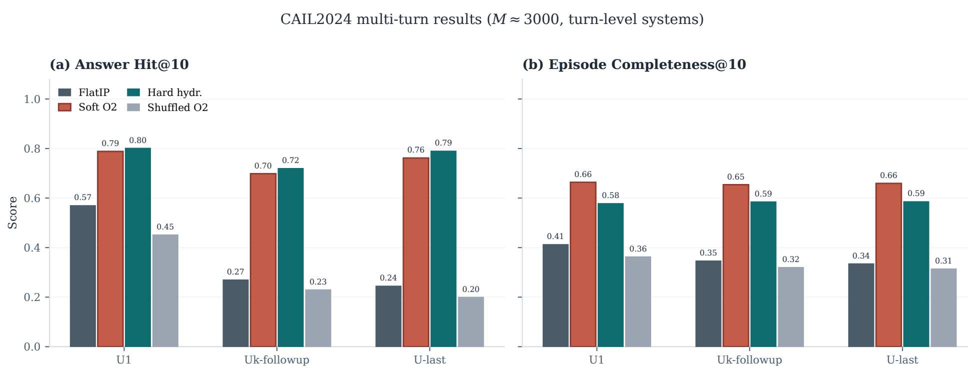

Figure 3: CAIL2024 multi-turn results at tier $M \approx 3000$ (published V4 AH/EC). Soft O2 improves AH and EC over FlatIP; shuffled *sid* removes the gain; hard expansion can maximize AH at a modest EC cost.

On LegalEp-DISC exact replay Soft O2 and FlatIP stay near-tied (0.638 vs 0.640), where both turns are already recoverable for many queries—consistent with treating exact as diagnostic. On Lawyer exact Soft O2 improves AH to 0.752 from FlatIP 0.692 (McNemar mid-p=0.024*). Paraphrase yields the clearest LegalEp gains: Soft O2 reaches 0.648 vs FlatIP 0.547 on DISC and 0.759 vs 0.568 on Lawyer, exceeding hard expansion on both corpora (mid-$p<0.001$** on both corpora). Advice-recall queries omit the stored question surface form: Soft O2 raises AH to 0.428 from FlatIP 0.342 on DISC and to 0.472 from 0.332 on Lawyer, again above hard expansion (mid-$p<0.001$**), while shuffled *sid* falls toward or below FlatIP. Corrected rebuild nDCG mirrors the same Soft O2>FlatIP ordering on paraphrase and advice-recall

Table 6: Corrected graded nDCG@10 (fixed-gold IDCG) under a fresh FlatIP rebuild. Boldface: Soft O2 better than FlatIP within each pair on AH and nDCG. Soft O2 also raises nDCG over shuffled *sid* on every listed channel. Distinct from published V4 AH/EC in Tables A.1–A.3.

Corpus	**Channel**	**System**	**AH@10**	**nDCG@10**	**Incomplete**
CAIL	Uk	FlatIP	0.458	0.445	54.0%
CAIL	Uk	Soft O2	**0.928**	**0.793**	7.0%
CAIL	Uk	Shuffled O2	0.347	0.369	65.2%
CAIL	U-last	FlatIP	0.425	0.420	57.3%
CAIL	U-last	Soft O2	**0.945**	**0.791**	5.3%
CAIL	U-last	Shuffled O2	0.287	0.348	71.2%
LegalEp-DISC	u-para	FlatIP	0.716	0.681	26.8%
LegalEp-DISC	u-para	Soft O2	**0.895**	**0.759**	8.7%
LegalEp-DISC	u-para	Shuffled O2	0.664	0.627	31.4%
LegalEp-DISC	advice	FlatIP	0.480	0.466	17.0%
LegalEp-DISC	advice	Soft O2	**0.608**	**0.524**	3.8%
LegalEp-DISC	advice	Shuffled O2	0.456	0.436	19.2%
LegalEp-Lawyer	u-para	FlatIP	0.739	0.744	25.3%
LegalEp-Lawyer	u-para	Soft O2	**0.946**	**0.844**	3.8%
LegalEp-Lawyer	u-para	Shuffled O2	0.729	0.705	25.5%
LegalEp-Lawyer	advice	FlatIP	0.444	0.483	23.4%
LegalEp-Lawyer	advice	Soft O2	**0.652**	**0.582**	2.2%
LegalEp-Lawyer	advice	Shuffled O2	0.424	0.454	25.0%

(Table 6). Detailed grids are in Tables A.2–A.3.

5.5. Soft O2-C effectiveness: Mix first, same-session as negative control

Soft O2-C is *not* meant to replace Soft O2 when gold already shares *sid*. We therefore lead with the setting where cluster binding can help, then show the same-session negative control.

Positive control (Mix / cross-session).. Table 7 reconstructs the same stores with 70% cross-session Sa/Sb gold and 30% intact same-session gold (RQ3–RQ4; gold-assisted Mix solvability bound, Section 4.3). Here Soft O2-C and gated Hybrid are evaluated against FlatIP and Soft O2 under unrestricted dense retrieval. On the cross-session stratum, Soft O2-C raises AH over Soft O2 on LegalEp-Lawyer (0.491 vs 0.446) and LegalMem-MT (0.537 vs 0.503), showing that cluster soft binding can recover split-episode gold when session membership alone cannot. Gated Hybrid Soft O2+Soft O2-C is the practical effectiveness operator: it improves overall AH on LegalEp-Lawyer

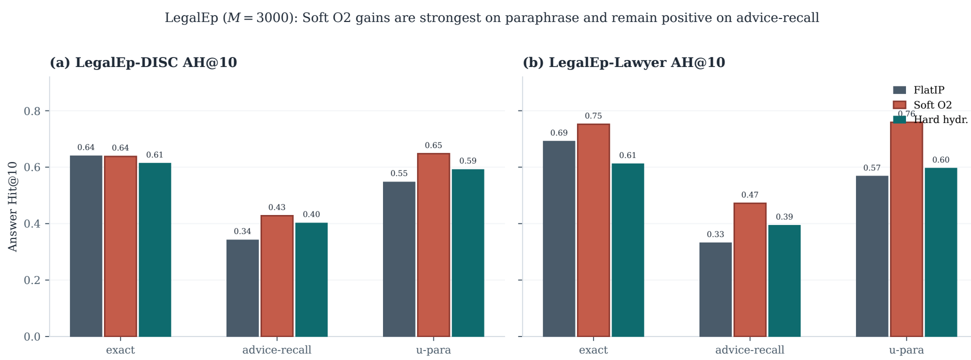

Figure 4: LegalEp AH@10 (M=3000, 500 needles). Soft O2 gains are strongest on paraphrase and remain positive on advice-recall; exact transfer is corpus-dependent and treated as diagnostic.

(0.534 vs Soft O2 0.496; mid-p=0.010*) and leads overall AH on LegalMem-MT (0.646 vs 0.618), while preserving most same-session hits (0.560 / 0.867). Ungated Soft O2-C alone often hurts overall AH because thematic confusers displace intact same-session evidence—hence Hybrid gates cluster binding on direct dense hits. Thus Soft O2-C is effective as a *complement* for cross-session recovery under the Mix bound, not as a drop-in Soft O2 replacement.

McNemar mid-p on paired Answer Hit; * p<0.05, ** p<0.01. Glue establishes a solvability bound (Section 4.3), not unsupervised deployment.

Negative control (same-session gold).. Table 8 uses standard stores where gold answers already share *sid* with the query. Ungated Soft O2-C underperforms Soft O2 on every channel because cluster siblings inject thematic confusers into an already solvable session-binding problem. This is an intentional negative control: it shows Soft O2 must remain the default same-session operator, and that Soft O2-C should be reserved for the Mix /cross-session regime above rather than enabled indiscriminately.

Together, Tables 7–8 enforce the staged narrative Soft O2 $\rightarrow$ Soft O2-C: Soft O2 is the default; Soft O2-C /Hybrid add cross-session recovery under a gold-assisted Mix bound; ungated Soft O2-C is not a free upgrade on co-session gold.

5.6. Controls, significance, scale, and QA audit

Lexical BM25-turn is competitive on exact replay (DISC exact 0.802) and weaker on advice-recall (0.382). Dense+BM25 RRF complements Soft O2

Table 7: Soft O2-C / Hybrid effectiveness under fair Mix (same store, unrestricted dense; AH@10). Gold is 70% cross-session Sa/Sb + 30% intact same-session. Boldface: best overall AH and best cross-session AH within each corpus. Soft O2-C can beat Soft O2 on AH_{cross}; Hybrid is the gated effectiveness operator. Significance vs Soft O2: $^{*}p<0.05$, $^{**}p<0.01$.

Corpus	System	AH	AH_{cross}	AH_{same}	mid-p vs Soft O2
LegalEp-DISC Mix	FlatIP	0.478	0.477	0.480	—
	Soft O2	0.482	0.443	**0.573**	—
	Soft O2-C	0.410	0.443	0.333	0.0004**
	Hybrid	**0.486**	**0.469**	0.527	0.8099
LegalEp-Lawyer Mix	FlatIP	0.462	0.454	0.480	—
	Soft O2	0.496	0.446	**0.613**	—
	Soft O2-C	0.464	0.491	0.400	0.0857
	Hybrid	**0.534***	**0.523**	0.560	0.0105*
LegalMem-MT Mix	FlatIP	0.534	0.526	0.553	—
	Soft O2	0.618	0.503	**0.887**	—
	Soft O2-C	0.500	0.537	0.413	0.0000**
	Hybrid	**0.646**	**0.551**	0.867	0.1837

Table 8: Negative control: same-session Soft O2 vs ungated Soft O2-C (AH@10). Gold shares *sid* with the query, so Soft O2 already has the right membership cue. Boldface: better AH within each row. Soft O2-C is expected to lose here; effectiveness is claimed in Table 7, not in this table.

Corpus / channel	Soft O2	Soft O2-C
LegalEp-DISC / exact	**0.836**	0.744
LegalEp-DISC / u-para	**0.807**	0.730
LegalEp-DISC / advice	**0.548**	0.490
LegalEp-Lawyer / exact	**0.818**	0.710
LegalEp-Lawyer / u-para	**0.817**	0.733
LegalEp-Lawyer / advice	**0.546**	0.448
LegalMem-MT / U1	**0.903**	0.712
LegalMem-MT / Uk	**0.793**	0.385

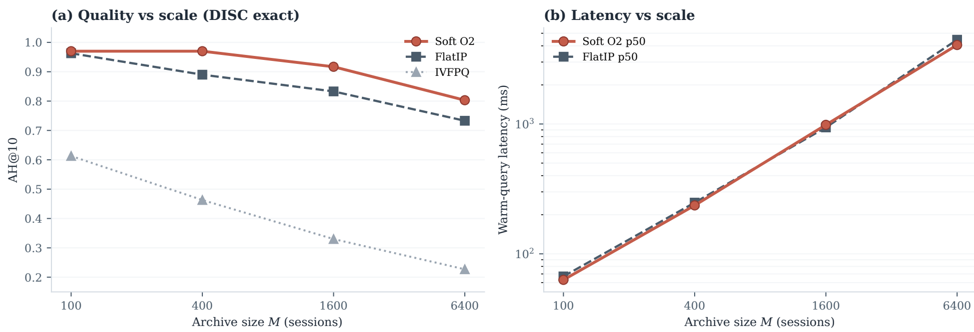

Figure 5: Scale curve on DISC-Law exact. Soft O2 keeps an AH edge over FlatIP as M grows; warm-query latency scales with archive size; IVFPQ quality collapses at moderate M.

on surface-overlap channels under the same turn-level unit. Cross-encoder reranking (`bge-reranker-v2-m3`, top-30) improves FlatIP inside the CE suite, yet remains below Soft O2 on CAIL (Uk FlatIP+CE 0.375 vs Soft O2 0.698; Table A.5). A β sweep peaks near $\{0.9, 0.95, 0.98\}$ and weakens at β=0.5 (Table A.6), consistent with the diagnostic gap-ratio band in Section 3.4 (Table 2). McNemar mid-p tests (Table A.7) show Soft O2 versus FlatIP highly significant on all CAIL channels and on LegalEp paraphrase /advice-recall.

Figure 5 and Table A.8 report quality and warm-query latency on LegalEp-DISC exact (Q=100, three repeats; $M \in \{100, 400, 1600, 6400\}$). Soft O2 retains an AH advantage at each tier; IVFPQ collapses at M=1600 (AH 0.330), motivating O1; absolute latency grows with M. We treat O1 FlatIP as an engineering prerequisite for Soft O2 at these scales and avoid claiming deployment readiness beyond the measured curve.

End-to-end QA audit (summary).. A dual-protocol QA audit (N=270 per corpus; generator `qwen3:14b`, independent judge `qwen3:32b`) links retrieval quality to downstream answerability under a *single* retrieval configuration (Soft O2); we do not claim causal superiority over FlatIP in generation without paired downstream controls. Full protocol and stratified results appear in Section 6.2. On an older revision-protocol store (M=400, five seeds), Soft O2 AH on LegalEp-DISC is 0.851 ± 0.008 versus FlatIP 0.698 ± 0.040.

6. Discussion

6.1. Findings and scope

RQ1–RQ2 show that episode incompleteness is a substantial recurrent FlatIP failure mode under same-domain interference, and that Soft O2 converts many incomplete retrievals into complete ones without shrinking session-miss rates (Table 4). O1 restores score fidelity as an implementation prerequisite; Soft O2 supplies the primary algorithmic gain through soft sibling inheritance; O3 enables archive construction at scale. The diagnostic gap-ratio analysis (Section 3.4) explains why β should remain close to but below unity, and why the validation sweep peaks in $\{0.9, 0.95, 0.98\}$ rather than at hard hydration (β=1). On CAIL, Soft O2 raises Answer Hit by large margins in the published V4 grids (U1 +0.218, Uk +0.428, U-last +0.517) with collapsing shuffled-*sid* controls, and keeps higher EC than hard expansion despite occasional AH ties. LegalEp paraphrase and advice-recall—not exact replay—carry the primary Soft O2 transfer claims. Corrected fixed-gold nDCG on a FlatIP rebuild corroborates the Soft O2>FlatIP ordering without replacing the V4 AH/EC transfer numbers (Table 6). RQ3–RQ4 follow Soft O2 $\rightarrow$ Soft O2-C: Mix Hybrid Soft O2+Soft O2-C recovers cross-session gold under a solvability bound (Table 7), while same-session ungated Soft O2-C is a negative control showing Soft O2 must stay the default (Table 8). Soft O2 (session) is the default operator; Soft O2-C /Hybrid (cluster) are complementary exploratory bounds within one BIMS-LEGAL dual-store. Sparse and fusion turn-level baselines situate Soft O2 among standard IR alternatives Robertson and Zaragoza (2009); Cormack et al. (2009); Nogueira et al. (2019); coarser joint-episode indexes were not evaluated as Soft O2 competitors.

6.2. RAG application perspective

Consultation-memory retrieval is judged downstream by whether an LLM can answer from recovered evidence rather than confabulate. We audit this end-to-end with a dual-protocol pipeline on Soft O2 retrieval only: generator `qwen3:14b` and independent judge `qwen3:32b` are distinct models. Per corpus we pool N=270 judged instances as P1 n=120 plus P2 n=150 (folder `legal_qa_n270`). Table 9 summarizes pooled Evidence-Answerability Rate (EAR) and stratified independent-judge scores. When Soft O2 retrieves complete episodes—both question and answer turns in top-k—the generator receives grounded prior advice and judged answerability rises in this single-system audit (pooled EAR 0.867 on DISC and 0.859 on Lawyer; Wilson 95% CI $[0.83, 0.90]$ / $[0.82, 0.89]$). Follow-up queries remain the hardest stratum (independent-judge EAR 0.517 / 0.480), consistent with episodic incompleteness persisting even when surface-form overlap is low.

A blind two-annotator legal audit (n=60/corpus) yields Cohen's κ=0.71 / 0.68 and separates retrieval from generation failures (retrieval-failure share 0.283 / 0.317). Wrong-session contamination rates stay low (0.083 / 0.100), suggesting that complete episode retrieval under Soft O2 is associated with lower rates of a common RAG failure mode in which the model answers from a neighbouring client's matter. Hallucinated-legal-basis rates (0.117 / 0.133) remain non-zero, indicating that grounding in retrieved episodes does not guarantee statutory correctness—a scope boundary for deployment. AH and EAR measure evidence availability and judged answerability respectively; statutory correctness, citation validity, and professional liability lie outside this evaluation.

Table 9: End-to-end QA audit (N=270 per corpus; generator `qwen3:14b`, independent judge `qwen3:32b`). EAR: Evidence-Answerability Rate (judge score $\geq$ 0.7). Stratified judge scores: n=90/corpus across exact, paraphrase, and follow-up protocols.

Corpus	**Pooled EAR**	**Stratified judge**	**Human κ**
DISC-Law	**0.867**	0.757	0.71
Lawyer-LLaMA	**0.859**	0.729	0.68

6.3. Limitations

LegalEp episodes are consultation pairs; multi-turn authenticity remains reserved for CAIL. Mix glue establishes a solvability bound for Soft O2-C evaluation (Section 4.3); natural same-cluster rates without glue are lower and are diagnostics only—real unsupervised BIRCH clustering would not receive split-pair metadata at build time. Soft O2 depends on correct session identifiers; Soft O2-C depends on cluster quality. BM25-joint and dense joint-episode document indexes were not included in Soft O2 primary comparisons because they change the retrieval evidence unit from turns to concatenated episodes; evaluating those coarser designs under a matched online-update protocol is left to future work. The β diagnostic is semi-empirical: it assumes a dominant distractor and a well-defined hit score, and the fitted ρ uses a stored user-turn embedding as an exact-channel query proxy; paraphrase /advice-recall gap laws may shift the feasible band slightly but leave the high-β operating region unchanged. LLM paraphrases need human audit. Statutory correctness, citation validity, and professional liability remain unevaluated. Multiple channels inflate comparison multiplicity; we therefore report Holm-corrected p-values for the primary Soft O2 vs FlatIP family (Table A.7) alongside uncorrected McNemar mid-p tests.

Latency and deployment scope.. Scale curves cover $M \in \{100, 400, 1600, 6400\}$ under a fixed hardware stack (Table A.8). At M=6400, warm-query p50 latency exceeds 4 s (4061 ms for Soft O2; 4458 ms for FlatIP)—unacceptable for millisecond interactive search. BIMS-LEGAL should therefore be positioned as **high-precision offline or quasi-real-time consultation memory recovery**—e.g., pre-meeting case review, audit replay, or batch RAG over a firm's advice archive—not as a sub-millisecond search engine. Future work will combine approximate nearest-neighbour indexes (e.g., HNSW) with Soft O2 and Soft O2-C binding layered on top of faithful candidate retrieval, preserving episode completion while reducing query latency. Behavior at roughly 10^5 sessions is not measured, and we do not claim asymptotic scalability from O3 wall-clock alone.

7. Conclusion

BIMS-LEGAL targets consultation-memory retrieval under same-domain interference in Chinese legal archives through a dual-store design: an episodic turn index paired with a BIRCH semantic store. Soft O2 session soft binding is the primary algorithmic contribution; Soft O2-C with gated Hybrid is an exploratory cluster-binding complement under a gold-assisted Mix solvability bound, with Soft O2 attenuation β validated on a diagnostic gap-ratio model; O1 exact indexing and O3 bulk-load consolidation are implementation operators that enable the shared-store ablations reported here. Under a shared-corpus protocol spanning CAIL multi-turn dialogues and rebuilt LegalEp episode corpora, Soft O2 improves Answer Hit over FlatIP on multi-turn, paraphrase, and advice-recall channels with collapsing shuffled-*sid* controls, yields higher episode completeness than hard expansion on CAIL, and raises corrected fixed-gold nDCG while reducing incompleteness. Same-store Soft O2-C underperforms Soft O2 when gold shares *sid*; under fair Mix reconstructions, gated Hybrid Soft O2+Soft O2-C can recover additional cross-session gold while Soft O2 remains strong on intact same-session gold. End-to-end QA audit links complete episode retrieval to judged answerability and low wrong-session contamination in downstream generation under Soft O2 retrieval. Sparse, fusion, and cross-encoder baselines situate Soft O2 among standard turn-level IR alternatives; joint episode / document-level indexes are a different input granularity and are not Soft O2 competitors in this protocol.

Declarations

Funding

Computational resources were provided by the Data Law Laboratory, China University of Political Science and Law.

Conflict of interest

The authors declare no competing interests.

Ethics approval

This study uses publicly released research corpora and excludes confidential client data. The system is a research prototype for consultation-memory retrieval.

Data availability

Code, processed evaluation corpora, and primary result files are publicly available at `https://github.com/Kilimajaro/soft-episode-binding-legal-memory`. Upstream legal corpora: CAIL2024 consultation tracks; Hugging Face `ShengbinYue/DISC-Law-SFT` and `Skepsun/lawyer_llama_data`.

Code availability

The BIMS-LEGAL implementation (O1 FlatIP, Soft O2, O3 bulk-load, Soft O2-C), LegalMem/LegalEp pipelines, Mix builders, and table/figure scripts are released in the same repository with JSON artifacts for each main table.

Author contributions

L.X. (University of Winnipeg) designed BIMS-LEGAL and the Soft O2 /Soft O2-C evaluation, implemented the system, ran the experiments, and wrote the manuscript. L.H. (corresponding author; CUPL Data Law Lab and Institute for Data Law) provided methodology guidance, revision, and supervision.

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Appendix A. Numeric grids and controls

Main Soft O2 claims are visualized in Figures 3–5; O1–O2 and Mix Soft O2-C tables appear in the main text. Tables below retain full Soft O2 numeric rows for reproducibility: published V4 AH/EC with corrected rebuild nDCG. Boldface follows AH/EC winners so that Soft O2's completeness advantage remains visible even when hard hydration leads AH.

Table A.1: CAIL2024 shared-corpus results ($M \approx 3000$). Boldface marks the best AH@10 and best EC@10 within each channel (ties bolded jointly). **: Soft O2 vs FlatIP, McNemar mid-p<0.01. Published V4 AH/EC are the Soft O2 transfer claims; nDCG@10 is corrected fixed-gold IDCG from a FlatIP rebuild and is not used for winner bolding.

Channel	**System**	**AH@10**	**EC@10**	**nDCG@10**	**95% CI (AH)**
U1	FlatIP	0.570	0.413	0.554	[0.530,0.610]
	Soft O2	0.788	**0.664**	0.776	[0.757,0.820]
	Hard hydr.	**0.802**	0.578	0.864	[0.768,0.835]
	Shuffled O2	0.452	0.363	0.411	[0.410,0.492]
Uk-followup	FlatIP	0.270	0.347	0.445	[0.237,0.307]
	Soft O2	0.698	**0.654**	0.793	[0.660,0.735]
	Hard hydr.	**0.720**	0.585	0.847	[0.685,0.753]
	Shuffled O2	0.230	0.320	0.369	[0.198,0.262]
U-last	FlatIP	0.245	0.335	0.420	[0.212,0.280]
	Soft O2	0.762	**0.659**	0.791	[0.725,0.797]
	Hard hydr.	**0.790**	0.586	0.854	[0.757,0.822]
	Shuffled O2	0.200	0.315	0.348	[0.172,0.232]

[†]nDCG@10 from fixed-gold IDCG FlatIP rebuild (`recompute_corrected_metrics.py`); published V4 AH/EC unchanged. Soft O2 leads EC; hard hydration can lead AH.

Table A.2: LegalEp-DISC (M=3000, 500 needles). Boldface: best AH@10 and best EC@10 within each channel. $^{*}p$<0.05, $^{**}p$<0.01 (Soft O2 vs FlatIP, McNemar mid-p). Hard hydration coincides with session-max aggregation; only hard hydration is shown. Published V4 AH/EC; nDCG@10 from corrected FlatIP rebuild (not used for winner bolding).

Channel	System	AH@10	EC@10	nDCG@10
exact	FlatIP	**0.640**	0.741	0.730
	Soft O2	0.638	**0.780**	0.813
	Hard hydr.	0.614	0.598	0.886
	Shuffled O2	0.448	0.645	0.666
advice-recall	FlatIP	0.342	0.438	0.466
	Soft O2	**0.428**	**0.503**	0.524
	Hard hydr.	0.402	0.405	0.572
	Shuffled O2	0.310	0.421	0.436
u-para	FlatIP	0.547	0.681	0.681
	Soft O2	**0.648**	**0.735**	0.759
	Hard hydr.	0.592	0.571	0.827
	Shuffled O2	0.469	0.610	0.627

Table A.3: LegalEp-Lawyer (M=3000, 500 needles). Boldface: best AH@10 and best EC@10 within each channel. $^{*}p$<0.05, $^{**}p$<0.01 (Soft O2 vs FlatIP). Hard hydration coincides with session-max aggregation; only hard hydration is shown. Published V4 AH/EC; nDCG@10 from corrected FlatIP rebuild (not used for winner bolding).

Channel	System	AH@10	EC@10	nDCG@10
exact	FlatIP	0.692	0.806	0.753
	Soft O2	**0.752**	**0.848**	0.869
	Hard hydr.	0.612	0.615	0.897
	Shuffled O2	0.570	0.747	0.705
advice-recall	FlatIP	0.332	0.464	0.483
	Soft O2	**0.472**	**0.540**	0.582
	Hard hydr.	0.394	0.403	0.601
	Shuffled O2	0.348	0.467	0.454
u-para	FlatIP	0.568	0.718	0.744
	Soft O2	**0.759**	**0.819**	0.844
	Hard hydr.	0.596	0.594	0.864
	Shuffled O2	0.592	0.712	0.705

Table A.4: Turn-level BM25 and dense+BM25 RRF (AH@10). Boldface: higher AH within each row among reported turn-level cells. BM25-joint / joint-episode document indexes are omitted: they change evidence granularity and were not run as Soft O2 protocol competitors.

Corpus	**Channel**	**AH@10**
LegalEp-DISC	exact (BM25-turn)	0.802
LegalEp-DISC	advice-recall (BM25-turn)	0.382
LegalEp-DISC	exact (dense+BM25 RRF)	0.780
LegalEp-DISC	advice (dense+BM25 RRF)	0.394
CAIL	U1 / Uk / U-last (BM25-turn)	0.748 / 0.482 / 0.413
LegalEp-Lawyer	exact / advice (BM25-turn)	0.784 / 0.460

Table A.5: Cross-encoder control (AH@10). FlatIP and FlatIP+CE are paired in the CE suite (`bge-reranker-v2-m3` over top-30 dense candidates). Boldface: best AH within each row. Soft O2 reproduces the primary evaluation; FlatIP here may differ slightly from primary FlatIP due to independent CE-suite re-indexing.

Corpus / channel	**FlatIP**	**FlatIP+CE**	**Soft O2**
CAIL / U1	0.585	0.688	0.788
CAIL / Uk	0.265	0.375	0.698
CAIL / U-last	0.228	0.342	0.762
LegalEp-DISC / exact	0.572	0.722	0.638
LegalEp-Lawyer / exact	0.636	0.708	0.752

Table A.6: Soft O2 AH@10 versus β on the primary shared-corpus evaluation. Peak performance lies in $\{0.9, 0.95, 0.98\}$; aggressive attenuation (β=0.5) weakens binding.

Corpus	0.5	0.7	0.9	0.95	0.98	1.0
CAIL / Uk	0.323	0.537	0.697	0.700	0.698	0.662
LegalEp-Lawyer / exact	0.608	0.654	0.754	0.754	0.752	0.752
LegalEp-Lawyer / u-para	0.631	0.637	0.717	0.745	0.759	0.749
LegalEp-DISC / u-para	0.551	0.551	0.618	0.648	0.648	0.642

Table A.7: McNemar mid-p on paired Answer Hit (Soft O2 vs FlatIP / hard hydration / FlatIP+CE). Holm-adjusted p is reported for the nine primary Soft O2 vs FlatIP contrasts.

Corpus / channel	**Contrast**	**ΔAH**	**mid-p**	**Holm p**
CAIL / Uk	O2 vs FlatIP	+0.428	8.99e-48	8.09e-47
CAIL / Uk	O2 vs Hard hydr.	-0.022	0.243	—
CAIL / U1	O2 vs FlatIP	+0.218	5.19e-18	4.67e-17
CAIL / U1	O2 vs Hard hydr.	-0.013	0.435	—
CAIL / U-last	O2 vs FlatIP	+0.517	5.51e-65	4.96e-64
CAIL / U-last	O2 vs Hard hydr.	-0.028	0.0982	—
CAIL / Uk	O2 vs FlatIP+CE	+0.323	2.50e-26	—
CAIL / U1	O2 vs FlatIP+CE	+0.100	3.51e-05	—
CAIL / U-last	O2 vs FlatIP+CE	+0.420	3.92e-41	—
LegalEp-DISC / exact	O2 vs FlatIP	-0.002	0.934	0.934
LegalEp-DISC / exact	O2 vs Hard hydr.	+0.024	0.302	—
LegalEp-Lawyer / exact	O2 vs FlatIP	+0.060	0.0239	0.191
LegalEp-Lawyer / exact	O2 vs Hard hydr.	+0.140	3.50e-10	—
LegalEp-DISC / u-para	O2 vs FlatIP	+0.101	7.95e-05	6.36e-04
LegalEp-DISC / u-para	O2 vs Hard hydr.	+0.056	0.035	—
LegalEp-Lawyer / u-para	O2 vs FlatIP	+0.191	2.10e-15	1.68e-14
LegalEp-Lawyer / u-para	O2 vs Hard hydr.	+0.163	7.57e-09	—
LegalEp-DISC / advice	O2 vs FlatIP	+0.086	1.25e-04	8.75e-04
LegalEp-DISC / advice	O2 vs Hard hydr.	+0.026	0.215	—
LegalEp-Lawyer / advice	O2 vs FlatIP	+0.140	1.18e-10	9.44e-10
LegalEp-Lawyer / advice	O2 vs Hard hydr.	+0.078	5.72e-04	—

Table A.8: Scale curve on DISC-Law (mean over 3 repeats). Latency is warm-query p50/p95. Boldface: best AH@10 within each M block; lowest p50/p95 within each M block.

M	**Mode**	**AH@10**	**Build (s)**	**p50 (ms)**	**p95 (ms)**
100	FlatIP	0.963	3.0	67	80
100	IVFPQ	0.613	**25.2**	**40**	**54**
100	Soft O2	**0.970**	3.2	63	69
400	FlatIP	0.890	26.5	248	305
400	IVFPQ	0.463	89.5	**171**	**204**
400	Soft O2	**0.970**	30.9	236	313
1600	FlatIP	0.833	359.8	**941**	1278
1600	IVFPQ	0.330	**251.4**	669	**751**
1600	Soft O2	**0.917**	393.7	985	1172
6400	FlatIP	0.733	**4722.8**	4458	4969
6400	IVFPQ	0.227	1072.1	**2182**	**3021**
6400	Soft O2	**0.803**	5245.7	4061	4503